building. And in 2010, we named the project ERPNext, launching it on a Software-as-a-Service (SAAS) business model.

In 2011, we moved from Google Code to GitHub, and that proved to be a turning point. Gradually we started positioning ourselves more as an open source ERP solution. Our end goal is to become a WordPress like tool for ERP systems.

Challenges faced

Being in India, we did not find any mentor or community that could help us in building an open source product. Whatever I learnt was from reading HackerNews and following other OSS projects. Seeing how popular open source projects operate is inspiring, but there are 100 steps that you need to take to reach there, so having contextual help was really important and we missed that. Somehow, we struggled and figured out a lot of stuff ourselves, maybe even unnecessarily reinventing the wheel a few times.

Also, having no existing community to tap into was frustrating. The only people still passionate about FOSS in India belong to the Linux era, and there were no real events where the community could gather and talk. So, there was a feeling of isolation in the first few years.

The current status of FOSS

While the ideological aspects have faded away, the movement has become very commercial. In fact, in my view, over-commercialisation is making it toxic. I think being too ideological in the early days has backfired and it would have been great if there was more Torvald-like pragmatism. Today it is very market driven. The good part about this is that consumers are benefiting. Today, most of the Internet runs on FOSS and so do most of the operating systems (on phones). For the kind of services we can enjoy today, we owe a huge debt to the ideological movement and

“Companies looking to expand markets at lower costs will leverage and continue funding FOSS activities”

we are glad to be enjoying the fruits of that movement.

Where is FOSS heading?

The market will continue to drive FOSS forward. Companies looking to expand markets at lower costs will leverage and continue funding FOSS activities. The ideological space has shrunk and even the political environment has become so toxic that taking FOSS forward is going to be difficult. Activities have moved on to other goals, like ensuring data privacy in this era of surveillance. Microsoft is no longer the evil empire and is now one of the largest contributors to FOSS.

So, we are entering into a more market driven era which is resulting in the creation of more and more free software, now mostly driven by large corporations.

India’s role in the global FOSS ecosystem

India has a very small FOSS community and its members too have moved on so, sadly, neither are there any new ideas. Apart from ERPNext, a few more companies are starting to publish open source libraries. Most of this is market driven and this trend will continue.

The government’s FOSS policy

Government procurement procedures are a nightmare and there is no way right minded companies can participate. Government-run institutes like the IITs are also nowhere near making any meaningful contributions to FOSS. And while the government has a FOSS policy, it’s a farce.

A free product like ERPNext can add so much value and savings to governments, but it is sad that there is no real interest to take things forward. The Indian government probably is dependent on ‘experts’ from big consulting firms who really don’t have the right incentives. Having worked with various government agencies, I am not sure they can do anything. It is more likely that they will be laggards in FOSS adoption and will follow the market.

“Government-run institutes like the IITs are also nowhere near making any meaningful contributions to FOSS. And while the government has a FOSS policy, it’s a farce.”

Build skills by doing more projects

Every young engineer today is working with FOSS in some way. Most of the Web related technologies are open source and so are most of the jobs. A lot of tech teams globally run lots of FOSS in their technology stack. My advice to youngsters would be to build skills by doing as many projects as they can. Most skills are transferable to any stack. So, building projects on Python, Node, etc, is a great way to start building a good resume, based on which a company can hire them. END